



Southern Africa Regional Policy Dialogue on Adaptation Accountability and the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA). Report

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1. Executive Summary

The Regional Africa Dialogue on Accountable Adaptation and the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA) convened policymakers, technical experts, researchers, civil society actors, and practitioners to interrogate how accountability is currently defined, operationalised, and measured within climate adaptation governance systems in Africa.

Across all sessions, a consistent finding emerged: adaptation governance in Africa is characterised by a structural accountability deficit, in which reporting systems prioritise upward compliance with donors and international frameworks over downward accountability to affected communities. This results in a disconnect between adaptation “outputs” (plans, strategies, reports) and adaptation “outcomes” (actual reductions in vulnerability and risk).

The dialogue identified three interrelated systemic tensions:

- Indicator–reality mismatch: Emerging GGA indicators risk privileging standardised global metrics that insufficiently capture local vulnerability dynamics and adaptive practices. *[UNFCCC GGA indicator framework / SBSTA discussions on adaptation metrics¹]*
- Institutional fragmentation: Adaptation responsibilities remain dispersed across sectoral departments (water, disaster risk, environment), often without sufficient coordination authority or fiscal control.
- Knowledge hierarchy imbalance: Technical and quantitative datasets dominate adaptation reporting systems, while lived experience, indigenous knowledge systems, and community-generated evidence remain under-integrated.

Despite these constraints, the dialogue also surfaced actionable pathways for reform, including multi-directional accountability systems, hybrid indicator frameworks, and institutionalised community feedback mechanisms. The overarching conclusion is that the effectiveness of adaptation depends not on the volume of reporting but on whether governance systems can demonstrate measurable improvements in community resilience, safety, and livelihood stability.

¹ <https://unfccc.int/topics/adaptation-and-resilience/workstreams/gga>

2. Opening and Contextual Framing

The event was moderated by Dr Tamuka Chekero, who opened the dialogue by framing adaptation as a present reality rather than a future challenge. Dr Mushonga (Deputy Director, Centre for the Advancement of Scholarship) and Akinyi J. Eurallyah, Research Associate & Program Manager - Africa Science-Policy Fellowship, Africa Research & Impact Network (ARIN), provided opening remarks, emphasising that adaptation is fundamentally about governance, justice, and the futures we collectively seek to build.

Charles Tonui delivered the “Setting the Scene” presentation, providing an in-depth analysis of the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA). His presentation highlighted the tension between standardised global measurements and the highly localised nature of adaptation interventions. He stressed that without careful design, global indicators risk creating reporting burdens that distract from local resilience-building.

3. Accountability in Adaptation Systems

Session 3 focused on the core governance question: *Accountability to whom, by whom, and for what?*

- **Dr Misheck Yagontha Munthali** (Principal Secretary, Ministry of Natural Resources, Malawi) presented on the challenges of integrating climate-resilient development within public administration. He highlighted that in many African contexts, accountability is currently bifurcated between national mandates and international donor requirements, often leaving local community needs underrepresented.
- **Aristotelis (Ari) Kapsosideris** (Gauteng Provincial Government, Department of Environment) shared insights from the South African sub-national experience. He outlined the accountability hierarchy, noting that while provinces and municipalities are responsible for implementation (water management, disaster risk reduction), they often lack the institutional ‘clout’ or clear mandates to ensure climate-resilient development across all sectors. His analysis of the Gauteng Climate Change Response Strategy served as a case study for the fragmentation of responsibilities.

4. GGA Indicators and Regional Realities

Session 5 addressed the critical role of indicators in shaping climate policy.

- **Dr Margaret Monyani** (OLAM Africa Research Institute) discussed the intersection of migration, climate, and digital governance. She argued that proposed indicators often fail to capture the movement of people caused by climate stress, effectively rendering significant portions of the population "invisible" in official reporting.
- **Molatelo Racheke** (Co-founder, African Youth Advisory Network) highlighted the role of youth-led advocacy in holding decision-makers accountable. He emphasised that indicators must be meaningful to the youth who will live with the long-term consequences of today's adaptation policies. He critiqued the tendency for international processes to prioritise technocratic data over the lived experiences of vulnerable populations.

5. Evidence, Transparency, and Community Engagement

Session 6 examined how transparency and feedback mechanisms strengthen adaptation outcomes.

- **Boitumelo Pihlela** (International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies) provided a practitioner's perspective on Protection, Gender, and Inclusion (PGI). She detailed how Community Engagement and Accountability (CEA) frameworks—when applied to humanitarian contexts—can serve as a model for broader development policy. She emphasised that transparency is not just about publishing a report but about ensuring communities have the power to influence the trajectory of interventions.
- **Dr Brighton Shoniwa** (North-West University) advocated for the use of Public-Private-Community Partnerships (PPCPs). His presentation argued that contemporary climate challenges are too complex for government alone to address. He proposed a multi-stakeholder approach in which community voice is institutionalised in the governance of public finance for climate projects.
- **Simbarashe Kanyimo** (PhD candidate, Africa University) presented findings from the Accountable Adaptation Fellowship, focusing on child protection

systems and rights-based responses to climate-induced displacement. His research served as a poignant reminder that vulnerable populations, particularly children, are the primary stakeholders in the success of adaptation.

6. Key Thematic Findings

6.1 Accountability Architecture: From Upward Compliance to Multi-Directional Governance

A dominant concern across contributions was the asymmetry in accountability flows. Current systems are primarily structured around upward reporting to national treasuries, donors, and multilateral climate funds, rather than accountability to communities experiencing climate risk.

Government perspectives highlighted that this dual accountability system (domestic + international) often creates administrative overload without corresponding improvements in local resilience outcomes.

A sub-national governance case further demonstrated that climate mandates at provincial and municipal levels are frequently underpowered relative to implementation responsibilities, resulting in what participants described as an “implementation–authority gap.”

Key implication: Accountability in adaptation must be reconceptualised as multi-directional, integrating:

- upward accountability (international reporting obligations),
- horizontal accountability (inter-sectoral coordination), and
- downward accountability (community verification and feedback).

6.2 Institutional Fragmentation and the “Siloed Adaptation System”

The dialogue consistently identified institutional fragmentation as a major barrier to effective adaptation governance.

Key observations included:

- i. Climate adaptation is often treated as a cross-cutting but institutionally marginal function, without central coordinating authority.

- ii. Sectoral departments (water, disaster management, infrastructure) operate with weak integration mechanisms.
- iii. Provincial and municipal entities carry implementation responsibility without proportional fiscal or regulatory authority.
- iv. This results in fragmented adaptation responses that undermine coherence, scalability, and long-term resilience planning.
- v. Policy implication: Several participants argued for elevating climate coordination functions to central planning or treasury-linked structures to ensure cross-sectoral enforcement capacity.

6.3 Global Indicators vs Local Realities (GGA Relevance Debate)

A central debate focused on the feasibility and relevance of emerging GGA indicators in African contexts.

Key concerns included:

- i. Invisibility of climate-induced mobility and displacement in current indicator frameworks
[climate migration literature / IDMC displacement datasets²]
- ii. Over-reliance on aggregate national metrics that obscure sub-national inequalities and differentiated vulnerability patterns.
- iii. Lack of age-disaggregated and gender-responsive indicators, particularly regarding youth migration, livelihood disruption, and education impacts.
- iv. Participants were warned that poorly designed indicators risk producing an “illusion of progress”, where reporting compliance increases without corresponding reductions in vulnerability.

Emerging consensus: A shift toward hybrid indicator systems is required, combining:

- quantitative climate risk metrics, and
- qualitative resilience and livelihood stability indicators.

² https://api.internal-displacement.org/sites/default/files/publications/documents/20181213-slow-onset-intro.pdf?_gl=1*1bi3izn*_ga*MjA0NzE5NzQuMTc4MTYxOTY4Mg..*_ga_PKVS5L6N8V*cZE3ODE2MTk2ODEkbzEkZzAkdDE3ODE2MTk2ODEkajYwJGwwJGgw

6.4 Evidence Systems: Rebalancing Knowledge Hierarchies

The dialogue highlighted a persistent hierarchy of evidence that privileges:

- technocratic climate modelling,
- formal statistical systems, and
- donor-driven reporting templates.
- At the same time, there is systematic underutilisation of:
- indigenous knowledge systems,
- community narratives, and
- participatory monitoring data.

Practitioners emphasised that community engagement mechanisms in humanitarian contexts demonstrate viable models for integrating lived experience into accountability systems, particularly through structured feedback loops.

Policy implication: Strengthening adaptation accountability requires the formal recognition of community-generated evidence as legitimate policy input rather than supplementary information.

6.5 Emerging Models: PPCPs and Participatory Governance

The concept of Public–Private–Community Partnerships (PPCPs) emerged as a potentially scalable governance innovation.

Participants argued that:

- climate adaptation exceeds the capacity of state actors alone,
- private sector resources and innovation must be aligned with public oversight, and
- Communities must occupy a formal role in design and evaluation processes.
- However, concerns were raised regarding:
- asymmetries of power in PPP arrangements, and
- risks of tokenistic community participation if not institutionally embedded.

7. Strategic Policy Recommendations

7.1 Establish Multi-Directional Accountability Systems

Adaptation governance should institutionalise structured feedback loops linking communities, implementing agencies, and national reporting systems.

Action point: Mandate community-level feedback mechanisms within all publicly funded adaptation programmes, with documented institutional response requirements.

7.2 Codify Adaptation Mandates into Law

To ensure institutional continuity across political cycles, adaptation reporting and accountability systems should be legally embedded.

Action point: Develop national adaptation legislation that formalises:

- reporting obligations,
- institutional coordination mandates, and
- transparency requirements.

[comparative climate governance legislation examples³⁴⁵⁶⁷]

7.3 Implement Hybrid Indicator Frameworks for GGA

Global adaptation indicators should be adapted through nationally contextualised frameworks.

Action point: Integrate:

- quantitative climate risk indicators, and
- qualitative socio-economic resilience metrics to reflect lived realities of adaptation outcomes.

³ <https://climateactiontracker.org/publications/climate-governance-in-south-africa/>

⁴ <https://legalfundi.com/plm-subchapters/laws-and-policies-on-climate-change-in-south-africa/>

⁵ <https://www.uk-cpa.org/media/4356/climate-change-governance-the-challenge-of-multi-level-action.pdf>

⁶ https://link.springer.com/rwe/10.1007/978-3-642-40455-9_9-1

⁷ <https://www.nature.com/collections/ffgdicgjid>

7.4 Institutionalise Public–Private–Community Partnerships (PPCPs)

PPCPs should be structured as governance mechanisms, not project delivery tools.

Action point: Develop formal PPCP frameworks with defined roles for:

- state oversight,
- private sector investment, and
- community co-production of evidence and monitoring.

7.5 Create Safe Institutional Learning Spaces

Current reporting systems discourage reporting failures, resulting in distorted performance narratives.

Action point: Establish protected review platforms where implementation challenges can be documented without punitive consequences, enabling adaptive governance learning.

7.6 Invest in Local Data Infrastructure

Effective accountability requires decentralised data systems capable of capturing real-time adaptation outcomes.

Action point: Direct climate finance toward:

- community-based monitoring systems,
- local adaptation data registries, and
- participatory data governance platforms.

8. Conclusion

The dialogue demonstrated that the effectiveness of climate adaptation governance in Africa is constrained less by the absence of frameworks and more by misaligned accountability systems, fragmented institutional structures, and under-integrated knowledge systems.

A core insight emerging from the discussion is that adaptation must be reframed from a compliance-driven reporting exercise to a governance system centred on measurable improvements in human well-being and resilience.

Ultimately, the legitimacy of the Global Goal on Adaptation will depend on whether it can accommodate contextual diversity, elevate local knowledge systems, and produce accountability mechanisms that are meaningful to the communities most affected by climate change.

